

EXCEL BAR CHART

Compare categories, especially long names

02

WHEN TO USE

- Data has **one category** and **one number**, and the category names are **long**.
- Answers: **Which category is highest or lowest?**
- Use it when names would be **cramped or rotated** on a column chart, or for ranked lists.

DATA EXAMPLE

	A	B
1	Department	Sales
2	Enterprise Sales	480,000
3	Consumer Electronics	360,000
4	Online Marketplace	290,000
5	Corporate Services	175,000

DATA ANALYST USE CASE

Example: **Department Performance**

QUESTION

Which department sells the most?

CHART

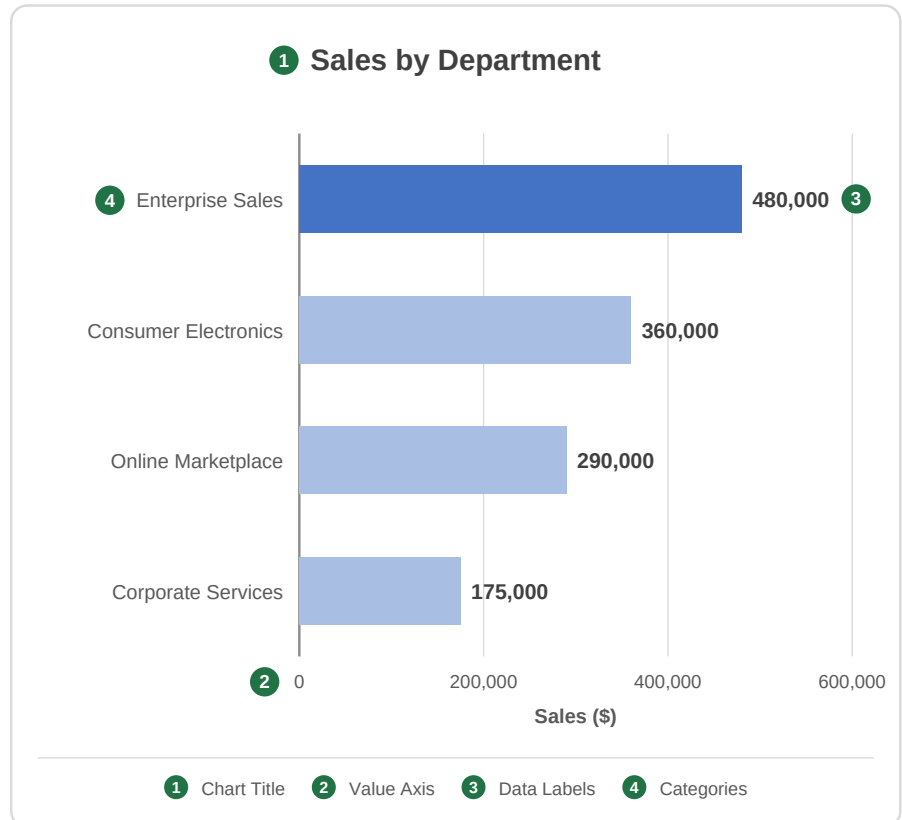
Bar Chart

INSIGHT

Enterprise Sales leads at 480,000, more than 2.7x the sales of Corporate Services (175,000).

BUSINESS QUESTION

- Which department generates the most sales?
- Which departments fall behind the others?
- How do departments rank from top to bottom?



HOW TO CREATE IT IN EXCEL



- 1** Select the data, including the headers (A1:B5).
- 2** Go to the **Insert** tab and open the **Charts** group.
- 3** Click **Insert Column or Bar Chart** > **2-D Bar** > **Clustered Bar**.
- 4** Add a **Chart Title**. Then **Format Axis** > **Categories in reverse order** so the largest bar is on top.
- 5** **Format**: add Data Labels at the bar ends and remove gridlines if labels show the values.

DO / DON'T

DO ✓

- ✓ Use bars when category names are long
- ✓ Sort so the largest bar is on top
- ✓ Start the value axis at zero
- ✓ Label values at the end of each bar

DON'T ✗

- ✗ Rotate long labels on a column chart
- ✗ Leave bars unsorted
- ✗ Truncate the axis to exaggerate gaps
- ✗ Use many colours for one series



DATA ANALYST TIP

When category names are long, switch from Column to Bar.

Horizontal bars read like a ranked list and keep every label readable.